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Disha IISER Pune

Volume II, Issue II

A Page from Abhyasika

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An Editor's Comments

It was a bright cold day in August 2012, when I was lying on my bed thinking about joining Disha. I had asked many people about the work done by the organization and had gotten mixed replies from them. Some of them really encouraged me to join Disha, describing the positive aspects of the organization while others were pessimistic regarding the work done by Disha. After weighing the positives with negatives, I decided to join Disha. And now, after participating in numerous events and programs over the years, I think I might be able to highlight the reasons why someone should join Disha.

Some of the common questions asked about Disha were, "Kya karna hai be wahan jaake? Waise bhi wo bacche sikhte nahi? Aur hame kya milne wala hai?" (What do we do? Anyway, they don't study and there is nothing to gain by going there?).

With these questions in mind one might ask, why should someone join Disha? I shall put forward three reasons why. Firstly, it greatly develops the volunteers. If you read the experiences shared by the volunteers in earlier editions of Pahal or Kalpa, you can observe that most of them have exclaimed that being a part of Disha was an enriching experience. They agreed that it was a platform for them to see and interact with that part of the society which is often ignored. So, according to me, it is a foolish question to ask "what are we to gain by doing this".

Secondly, it is an ideal opportunity for children in Laman vasti/construction site to learn English, Maths and Marathi in an exciting manner. Many children have the drive and intellect to study, but don't get a chance to go to school due to lack of resources. I think that the least we can do as an educated member of the society is to help these children in whatever way possible.

Thirdly, being a volunteer, one gains the confidence that he is not just a silent spectator but can change the society if he wishes to. The belief that the society cannot change is so ingrained into our minds that we do not have the motivation to improve it. But being a member of Disha can help you change your opinion regarding this matter.

Still somebody might ask, "Why should I care about these things and why above all the people, I should go teach kids?" This is a question which is there in the minds of many people. I would like to answer this question with a story. Remember Aladin? In that story, there is a big luxurious palace and surrounding the palace are slums. You can see how that is true for IISER and the construction site kids. IISER is an educational hub and the slums where kids live is a stone's throw from the Lecture Hall Complex. Is it really so difficult for us students of IISER to share some of our knowledge among kids in Laman vasti and construction site? If these children grow up to become highly regarded individuals, wouldn't it help the society? Think about it.

Suvidyakumar Homkar

Introducing “Mind Spark”

“Mind spark” is one of the innovative program started this year by Disha, IISER Pune. The main motive behind starting this new program is that, there is still lack of motivation and proper guidance to talented students in our society who really want to do something innovative in future. Mind spark has been started with aim of providing proper guidance and uplifting these students in this competitive world from earlier classes. It is an interactive platform that gives a glimmer to student’s ideas and makes them to enjoy what they learn. The main aim of this program is to make them stand in today’s competitive world. We try to form a strong foundation which help them in developing competitive skills. Instead of giving emphasis on factual teaching, we assist them to observe and experience things which helps in building scientific attitude. This kind of learning clears their misconceptions, allow them to understand things in more logical way and help to become self-reliant.



Photo courtesy: Manish Tekam



Photo courtesy: Manish Tekam

This program basically focuses on preparing around 25 selected 6th standard students from 5 different MNC schools nearby IISER, Pune for “7th class scholarship exam”-being conducted by Maharashtra state government every year. It is being conducted 4 days in a week at Multipurpose Hall -HR4, IISER Pune. We are trying to make their basic concepts in math’s and science stronger, so that in future they will face different competitive exams very easily. Apart from regular lectures, we also organize guest lectures on different science topics. At last but not least, we hope for great success in this one year.

Sharada Sarjane, BS-MS, 1st year

First Impressions of “Mind Spark”

Before MINDSPARK started each one of us would teach at most 3 children at a time but this is for the first time that we are teaching this big a class and it is quite an experience. It made us realize that teaching is not just about making them learn but also creating an environment that will enhance their curiosity of learning. We are now able to build a good relationship which has given them liberty to express their doubts without the feeling of shy and fear. We

have learnt to explain complex concepts in the simplest possible way and have patience till they understand it properly. This has definitely changed our perspective towards our own teachers.

Akashata Meshram, Aboli Ektare

BS-MS, 1st year

“Spread the Smile”

To bring education to one and all and to motivate young minds to realize their potential is Disha's noble aim. Toward this end, Disha organizes an annual initiative – “Spread the Smile” – to bring the joy of science and interactive teaching to school children in villages around Pune.

“Spread the Smile” is a month long program which involves volunteers visiting various villages over four weekends. The idea is to make the children realize that science is fun with help of science demonstrations and experiments. This year it was held from mid-January to mid-February at six villages.

People volunteered from not just IISER, but also from other places in Pune and Mumbai. The respective village coordinators decided the tentative schedule of the weekend workshop, which involved demonstrations of science experiments in the mornings, followed by sessions of interactive puzzles, games, model

making or movie sessions. Younger kids were made to do stuff like origami, art and craft.

This was my first experience as a volunteer and a village sub-coordinator of a village called “Vazeghar”, which is the farthest of all. It was an experience to marvel. The joy on the faces of those kids just as we arrived at their school was worth the hectic travelling. The principle warmly welcomed us and was very cooperative throughout the demonstrations. He even suggested a few things to improve this program. The kids responded enthusiastically to our questions and seemed to enjoy it. In the evening, some kids were trying their hand at math puzzles, some played cricket with the volunteers while others played dumb charades with us. It gave me tremendous joy when a month later, when I revisited the place, a girl came up to me and said with a smile, “Didi, vo jo khel sikhaya tha na, ab hum sab khelte



hain!” (Didi, now we all play the game that you taught us the last time!).

Another thing that touched me and many others was the way the villagers treated us as one of their own children and accepted us whole heartedly into their homes, and served delicious food. The fresh buffalo milk, the sweet sugarcane sticks, the adventurous tractor-trolley ride, the huge haystacks and the scenic beauty of the village and most importantly, the smile spread across the little souls' faces will forever be etched in our hearts.

Danish Kaur Pannu

First Impressions of Spread the Smile

One of our teachers informed us about Spread The Smile and the idea enthused us so much that a majority of us volunteered for this activity.

The village assigned to us was Kamthadi, Bhore. We had to interact with students from 8th, 9th and 10th standard students. The topic for our weekend was Chemistry according to which we designed

our activities. We started with a general introduction about Science and its scope. We encouraged the students to pursue and build careers in Science. We conducted different academic and fun sessions for the students.

Interacting with the students, answering their questions, learning about their lifestyle proved to be a wonderful experi-

ence. We learnt a lot from them. The villager's hospitality was heart-warming. Our co-volunteers from IISER have become great friends. The experience at Kamthadi will be cherished forever and we all look forward to be a part of this amazing initiative again next year.

Akanksha, Nidhi and Natasha



Reports from Vigyan Mela 2015

Vigyan mela is an event which is organised once in a year for the children Laman Vasti and Sanjay Gandhi Vasahat, where Disha runs regular abhyasikas. This my favourite event because the energy I feel among the children as well as the volunteers of Disha during this event is not comparable with any other event. The aim of this two-day activity is to bring the children from both the Vastis together and make them enjoy the pleasure of learning and creativity.

This year, we conducted Vigyan Mela on 27th and 28th of April, 2015. We enjoyed these two days with full enthusiasm. In the afternoon, we conducted a cleanliness drive in collaboration with Prutha (the green club of IISER Pune), which had a really good response from the children. In the evening, Vigyan Mela was inaugurated by Mrs. Chavan (mami), without whose support and help we could not have been successful in running abhyasikas in the vastis. Then, children sang songs and also some of them gave small speeches in front of the crowd, which improved their confidence level. Then, at night, we had organised a sky-watching session for the residents of both the vastis which had an overwhelming response. We showed moon to the children and also their parents, who were really amazed after seeing the craters on it.

On the next day, we brought elder children to IISER campus and simultaneously conducted sessions for the smaller children like origami, diya painting, drawing competition, etc. For the children who were brought in IISER campus, one of the professors in IISER, Dr. Bhas Bapat, conducted a session on 'Sound' experiments followed by a similar session of experiments by the volunteers of Disha. Then, after a small tea break, children watched a documentary on Earth. The 3-D movie session in which blue-red glasses were made and a blue-red 3-D film was shown to them, which they enjoyed a lot.



Photo courtesy: Manish tekam

In the afternoon, we had a session of clay-modelling for the small kids, which could not go well due to some problems. But the bridge making, and math puzzle, mehndi competition really went well. In the evening, IISER Pune Drama Club performed a short street-play on 'the condition of modern India today', which attracted many residents and the event was concluded by distributing gifts to the children who participated and did a good job in the competitions organised.

This time we had some difficulties in management. Some events did not go as well as they should have gone. But the most striking thing, which was achieved in this 'Vigyan Mela 2015', was that the other clubs of IISER Pune participated actively and contributed to spread smile on the faces of the kids there. The sky-watching session brought amazement on the faces of the elder ones also.

'Vigyan Mela' is an event, which increases the enthusiasm and encourages the volunteers of Disha and also the children in Vastis, which are an integral part of Disha. I guess that was achieved to a large extent during this year's Vigyan Mela.

Prachi Atmasiddha

3rd Year BS/MS

A Page from Abhyasika

I remember making a resolution on my very first day in IISER. I had firmly decided that I would not join any clubs in my first semester. Even after the touching Disha orientation session I was firm. My resolution was not shaken. However I was really impressed by the concept of Disha and particularly the Abhyasikas. The idea of going into slum areas and teaching the kids there really appealed to me. I was curious to know more and therefore attended the second orientation session. I told myself that I would definitely join Disha in my second semester. Keeping this in mind, I went to one of the two Abhyasikas with a couple of seniors on the very next day. In a matter of minutes, my resolution lay in pieces. I immediately signed up for the Lamanvasti Abhyasika.

I was completely overwhelmed after the first few classes. The Lamanvasti Abhyasika was a new one and there was a lot to be done. All I had to do was teach the kids numbers and al-

phabets one hour a day, two days a week. Simple enough in theory but highly challenging in reality. The children were enthusiastic but

"I was completely overwhelmed after the first few classes. The Lamanvasti Abhyasika was a new one and there was a lot to be done. All I had to do was teach the kids numbers....."

unruly. They came and left as they pleased. We were lucky if the children actually heard half of what we were trying to say. They made trouble in every way possible. The lighting was poor and the place was a mess. But at the end of the day I didn't feel angry, resentful or hurt. I felt satisfied. All of it was worth it. Of course there was a lot

to be done but the joy of watching the children learn pushed us on.

The second half of the semester brought with it a series of changes. By then most of us were used to the routine and so we could spend our time actually teaching the kids instead of controlling them. We divided them into batches so that we could give individual attention to every single child. Although they still made trouble, we could control them. We were making progress, one step at a time.

Today the Abhyasika is running really well. Sure we have to face new problems every day. But so long as we keep our ultimate aim in mind, I think we'll manage. I joined the Abhyasika to teach the underprivileged children but I think I have learned more than I have taught. Teaching in the Abhyasika is the most exhausting but rewarding thing I have ever done. I am sincerely thankful that I got a chance to be a part of it all.

Mitali Thatte

First Impressions of Weekend Program

It all started with that lazy Sunday morning. I was in my room when Suraj came there banging the door like anything. He asked me whether I was free. Then he asked me to whether I would like to go for Disha Weekend programme which used to be held in LHC. Then I thought that I should give it a try. The first day experience was great. I met the coordinators, the volunteers and the kids. The science sessions, the scientific demonstrations, the toys

all of it was great. Thus it all began.

I started going to each weekend and attended each session. The way the volunteers used to teach was impressive. It was funny and as well as educating for the kids. I could remember all the moments of the sessions, the questions the students used to ask and all of it.

Teaching the kids and learning with the kids both are two different experiences. But both of them

are great. There we not only taught, but we also learned how to teach. We also learned how to interact with the kids, how to reach their mind set and think. I never thought that teaching would be fun like this.

So I learned there how to teach the student by being a student.

Aniket Khairnar
BS/MS 1st Year

Talk Reviews : Talk for Twenty

Talk for twenty is a public talk event organized by Disha every alternate Sunday. Talks are about any issues concerning society and the duration of the talk is 20 minutes followed by debates and discussions. Talking doesn't appear to be an immediate solution to any social problem but it is a powerful tool for transforming society in a long run. For many complex social problems, awareness among the mass appears to be the only permanent solution and talking is the first step towards creating awareness. It also helps uncover different social problems which is unfamiliar to us.

The speakers of this talk can be anyone from any profession and any age like students, faculty, members of any NGO etc. Hence one finds talks on diverse topics. "Education under globalization", "GREEN India", "Sexual slavery", "Self change as precondition for social change", "Little steps towards greener society" were some



only condemned unreasonable actions of society towards menstruating women but without hesitation, answered all "uncomfortable" questions from the audience. I can say with confidence that those who attended the talk went home being a little more broad-minded. Now this is a best example how talking, along with creating social awareness, can break social barriers as well.

Photo courtesy: Rajath Sawant

motivate people by introducing them to revolutionary ideas and kindling in them a desire for change.

The abstract of the talk will be updated on the blog regularly. It is being planned to put up videos of the talks on the website. Talk for twenty is always an open platform



of the topics on which talks happened this year. Out of these, the most interesting and unique talk was "Social taboos around menstruation". Speaker of this talk was Shipra Kumar a BS-MS student. Shipra through this talk not

for any organization to work efficiently, must have a firm ideological base and specific goals to achieve. Talk for twenty plays a role of pumping in new ideas into Disha and help define new goals for it. It is just a small effort to

for anyone who wants to put forth his/her innovative ideas.

To participate as a speaker write to disha.iiserpune@gmail.com

Rajath Sawant

Picture Collage



